

Get Started with Contributing to Open Source

Here's a beginner's guide to making open source contributions.



Open source software' is a term we come across fairly often in our daily lives, but have a faint idea of what it entails. I remember my first questions about it.

"Is it code? Like huge files with complicated functions that I have no clue about?"

The answer to that is, it's not. Not all open source software (OSS) comprise code bases that can cover the surface of the pyramids. And hardly any of it is as esoteric as hieroglyphics. In fact, most open source software comprises easily understood code maintained by diverse people ranging from 12-year-old school kids in Russia to 80-year-old Nobel laureates in Antarctica, and everyone in between. Most open source enthusiasts take it up as a hobby or pastime, while contributing to the 'greater good'.

"Alright, but I can't code!"

Open source contributions are not just about writing code. In fact, OSS would have died out a long time ago if it hadn't been for those 'non-coders' who helped the community out by adding documentation for the code.

Equally important are the people who contributed their time to answering questions regarding these projects and others that contributed towards adding examples to the project in order to make it easier for beginners to understand uses for the software. There are people who have curated the mailing lists for the project, in turn learning much more about

it than they had originally expected. Life surprises you and so does OSS, it would seem.

If none of this appeals to you, there are still others who contribute by organising meet-ups or video conferences for a particular OSS project or even just a fun get-together! Everyone is an open source contributor as long as one is helping others out in whatever capacity one can. It can be an extremely rewarding process, as you will eventually find out!

"So it's probably stuff I can do. But why should I do it?"

There are a number of reasons that can motivate you to take up open source contribution, ranging from community welfare to personal gain:

1. It results in quality code being accessible to developers who rely on it for their work, thus avoiding having to rewrite functions from scratch since they have free access to open source software.
2. The sense of accomplishment after submitting your contributions, which could be used internationally, is simply fantastic! Imagine someone in a remote cabin in Alaska reading your solution, and sending up prayers of thanks to God for your help in resolving an issue with his installation.
3. The badge you wear with respect to your track record is for all to see. Regular contributors are valued for their skills as well as respected in the open source community. Who knows when a recruiter might come across it and recognise your efforts...